

1. Ancient History: Buddhism & Jainism

Q1.

The Second Buddhist Council was held at Vaishali during the reign of which king of the Shishunaga dynasty?

- A) Ajatashatru
- B) Kalasoka
- C) Ashoka
- D) Kanishka

Answer: B) Kalasoka

Exam Source: SSC CGL 2020 | SSC CHSL 2021 | SSC CPO 2019

Detailed Explanation: The Second Buddhist Council took place around 383 BCE at Vaishali under the patronage of King **Kalasoka** (Kalasoka/Kakavarna) and was presided over by Sabakami.

- **1st Council:** Rajgir (Ajatashatru, Haryanka Dynasty)
- **2nd Council:** Vaishali (Kalasoka, Shishunaga Dynasty)
- **3rd Council:** Pataliputra (Ashoka, Maurya Dynasty)
- **4th Council:** Kundalvana, Kashmir (Kanishka, Kushan Dynasty)

Q2.

At which ancient city did Lord Gautama Buddha attain *Mahaparinirvana* (final release/death)?

- A) Sarnath
- B) Kushinagar
- C) Bodh Gaya
- D) Lumbini

Answer: B) Kushinagar

Exam Source: RRB NTPC 2021 (CBT-1) | SSC CGL 2020 | UPSC CDS 2018

Detailed Explanation: Gautama Buddha passed away at the age of 80 at **Kushinagar** (in modern Uttar Pradesh), which was the capital of the ancient Malla republic.

- **Lumbini** = Birthplace
- **Bodh Gaya** = Enlightenment (*Nirvana*) under the Bodhi tree
- **Sarnath** = First sermon (*Dharmachakra Pravartana*)
- **Kushinagar** = Death (*Mahaparinirvana*)

2. Ancient History: Sangam Age

Q3.

Which animal served as the official royal emblem of the Chola dynasty during the Sangam period?

- **A) Bow and Arrow**
- **B) Tiger**
- **C) Carp (Fish)**
- **D) Elephant**

Answer: B) Tiger

Exam Source: SSC CGL 2021 | SSC CPO 2020 | SSC CHSL 2022

Detailed Explanation: The "Muvendar" (three crowned kings) of the Tamil Sangam age each possessed a distinct royal crest:

- **Cholas:** Tiger (Capital: Uraiyr / Puhar)
- **Cheras:** Bow and Arrow (Capital: Vanji / Karur)
- **Pandys:** Carp / Twin Fish (Capital: Madurai)

Q4.

Which ancient Tamil literary work, authored by Tolkappiyar, is considered the earliest surviving work of Tamil grammar and literature?

- **A) Silappadikaram**
- **B) Manimekalai**
- **C) Tolkappiyam**
- **D) Tirukkural**

Answer: C) Tolkappiyam

Exam Source: SSC CGL 2022 | SSC CHSL 2020 | SSC CPO 2019

Detailed Explanation: **Tolkappiyam** is the oldest extant work of Tamil literature and grammar, composed by Tolkappiyar (one of the twelve disciples of Sage Agastya). *Silappadikaram* (by Ilango Adigal) and *Manimekalai* (by Chithalai Chathanar) are the two primary Tamil epics written later.

3. Indian Geography: Northern Plains

Q5.

Majuli, officially recognized as the world's largest inhabited riverine island, is formed by which river system in the Northern Plains?

- **A) Ganga**
- **B) Yamuna**

- C) Brahmaputra
- D) Indus

Answer: C) Brahmaputra

Exam Source: RRB NTPC 2016 (CBT-1) | RRB NTPC 2021 (CBT-1) | SSC CGL 2019

Detailed Explanation: Majuli is a large freshwater island in the Brahmaputra River in Assam. It is formed by the main channel of the Brahmaputra to the south and the Kherkutia Xuti (an anabranch) joined by the Subansiri River to the north. In 2016, it became the first island district in India.

Q6.

The section of the Northern Plains lying between the Ghaggar and Teesta rivers is broadly categorized as the:

- A) Punjab Plains
- B) Ganga Plains
- C) Brahmaputra Plains
- D) Kashmir Plains

Answer: B) Ganga Plains

Exam Source: SSC CGL 2021 | SSC CHSL 2021 | SSC CPO 2020

Detailed Explanation: Geographically, the Northern Great Plains are divided into three major regional belts:

- **Punjab Plains (West):** Drained by the Indus and its five tributaries.
- **Ganga Plains (Middle):** Extends between the **Ghaggar** (Haryana/UP border) and **Teesta** (West Bengal) rivers across UP, Bihar, Haryana, Delhi, and West Bengal.
- **Brahmaputra Plains (East):** Lies predominantly in Assam.

4. Indian Geography: Peninsular Plateau

Q7.

Which Peninsular river is popularly referred to as 'Dakshin Ganga' or 'Vridha Ganga' due to its vast drainage basin size and length?

- A) Krishna
- B) Kaveri
- C) Godavari
- D) Narmada

Answer: C) Godavari

Exam Source: RRB NTPC 2021 (CBT-1) | SSC CGL 2021 | RRB JE 2019

Detailed Explanation:

- **Godavari** (1,465 km) is the longest river of Peninsular India, originating at Trimbakeshwar (Nashik, Maharashtra). It is called **Dakshin Ganga** or **Vridha Ganga** (Old Ganga) because of its age, length, and massive basin area.
- **Kaveri** is often referred to as the "Ganga of the South" due to its sanctity and perennial water flow fed by dual monsoons.

Q8.

Which is the highest mountain peak in the Western Ghats as well as the entire Peninsular India?

- **A) Doddabetta**
- **B) Anamudi**
- **C) Guru Shikhar**
- **D) Kalsubai**

Answer: B) Anamudi

Exam Source: SSC CGL 2020 | SSC CPO 2019 | SSC CHSL 2021

Detailed Explanation: **Anamudi** (2,695 m), located in the Anaimalai Hills of Kerala, is the highest peak in Peninsular South India.

- **Doddabetta** (2,637 m) = Highest peak in the Nilgiri Hills.
- **Guru Shikhar** (1,722 m) = Highest peak of the Aravalli Range (Rajasthan).
- **Kalsubai** (1,646 m) = Highest peak in Maharashtra (Sahyadri range).

5. Indian Geography: Islands & Coasts

Q9.

India's only active volcano is located on which of the following islands in the Andaman and Nicobar group?

- **A) Narcondam Island**
- **B) Barren Island**
- **C) Ross Island**
- **D) Viper Island**

Answer: B) Barren Island

Exam Source: SSC CGL 2021 | SSC CPO 2020 | SSC CHSL 2020

Detailed Explanation: **Barren Island**, situated approximately 138 km northeast of Port Blair in the Andaman Sea, holds South Asia's only confirmed active volcano. **Narcondam Island**, located further northeast, is a dormant volcanic island.

Q10.

The coastal stretch extending along the western coast of India from Daman in the north to Goa in the south is known as the:

- **A)** Malabar Coast
- **B)** Konkan Coast
- **C)** Coromandel Coast
- **D)** Utkal Coast

Answer: B) Konkan Coast

Exam Source: SSC CGL 2022 | SSC CHSL 2021 | SSC CPO 2019

Detailed Explanation: The Western Coastal Plains of India are divided into three distinct segments:

- **Konkan Coast:** Daman/Maharashtra to Goa (Northern stretch)
- **Kannada / Canara Coast:** Goa to Mangalore (Central stretch)
- **Malabar Coast:** Mangalore to Kanyakumari / Kerala (Southern stretch)